

Example Assignment. Explain Descartes' views on mind-body interaction, Princess Elisabeth's objection, and Descartes' reply. In your opinion, is the objections successful? Max. 500 words, 16 words/sentence.

Princess Elisabeth's Objection to Descartes' Interactionist Dualism

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In this paper, I will summarize and evaluate a debate between Descartes and Princess Elisabeth. First, I'll describe Descartes' views on mind-body interaction. Second, I'll describe Princess Elisabeth's main objection that physical to non-physical causation seems impossible. Third, I'll describe Descartes' most convincing reply. Finally, I'll try to assess whether Descartes' reply is successful.

Descartes' view can be captured in three basic claims. (1) The body is physical while the mind is not. It follows that they are distinct things. (2) The body can causally affect the mind. (3) The mind can causally affect the body. (2) and (3) occur through an intermediary point in the brain. (Descartes 1649, §27-36) For example, suppose you decide to drink the beer in front of you. The decision is a mental event, so according to (1), not physical. The decision causes a change in your brain, a physical thing. Then signals from your brain cause your arm to reach out. The causal connection between the decision and the brain change is an example of (3). Descartes thought there were constant interactions like this between the physical body and non-physical mind.

Princess Elisabeth raised an important objection to this kind of view. Suppose a mental event M causes an event in the body. Then M must cause something to move in the body (for example, an "animal spirit"). But to cause something to move, one must come into contact with it. And contact, by definition, means that two extended surfaces are touching. So M must be extended. But as Descartes himself argued, if something is extended, it is physical. Therefore, the mental event M must be physical. (Descartes and Elisabeth 1643, p. 6.v.) But this contradicts Descartes' dualism. So mental causation must work without contact, but how? Princess Elisabeth objected that no other explanation seems possible. So non-physical to physical causation seems impossible.

Descartes' reply to this objection has to do with "basic" concepts. He first denies that mind-to-body causation requires contact. And he agrees that there is no explanation in terms of physical causation. But we all have "basic" concepts. We use them to make sense of the world. These concepts cannot be explained in terms of other concepts. Mind-body causation is one of these. It cannot be explained in terms of physical causation. But this doesn't mean it is impossible.

(Descartes and Princess Elisabeth 1643, Descartes and Elisabeth 1643, p. 21.v.)

In my opinion, there is no clear winner in this debate. On one hand, Princess Elisabeth has shown that there are real negatives to Descartes' view. Non-physical to physical causation cannot be explained. On the other hand, Descartes' response shows that his position isn't absurd. (Even in contemporary physics there are "basic" concepts.) So should we believe Descartes' view? Princess Elisabeth gives us a reason not to, but not a decisive reason. The answer will depend on what other arguments there are for and against interactionist dualism.

References

Descartes, R. (1649). *The Passions of the Soul*. Trans. by J. Bennet (2009). www.earlymoderntexts.com.
Descartes, R. and Princess Elisabeth (1643). *Correspondence between Descartes and Princess Elisabeth*. Trans. by J. Bennet (2009). <http://www.earlymoderntexts.com/>.